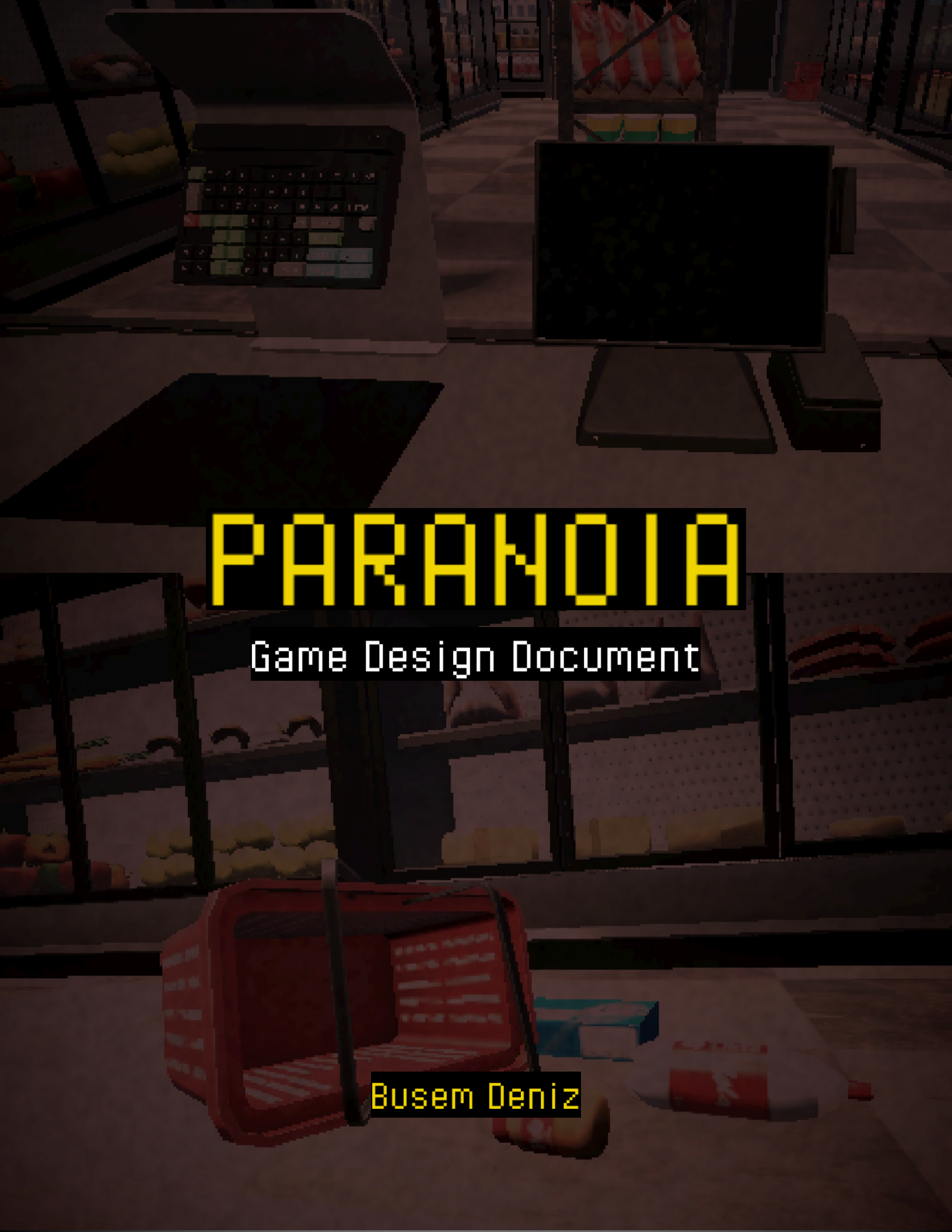


PARANOIA

Game Design Document

Busem Deniz

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Game Vision

1.1 Vision Statement

A psychological horror game that challenges the player to question whether the perceived danger is real or a product of fear. Set in a mundane supermarket, the game explores how social pressure and self-doubt can distort judgment where the most dangerous threat becomes the possibility of being right.

1.2 Executive Summary

Paranoia is a narrative-driven psychological horror game inspired by a true story posted online. The player assumes the role of Ashley, a young grocery store worker in the late 1990s, whose ordinary routine escalates into a disturbing encounter with two men. Rather than relying on combat or gore, the game grounds its horror in social pressure, manipulation, and the uncertainty of whether perceived danger is real or imagined.

The game is experienced entirely from a first-person perspective, with all information filtered through Ashley's perception. Gameplay centers on slow exploration and socially driven interaction within a mundane supermarket and its immediate aftermath. The player navigates the environment, inspecting objects to uncover the protagonist's inner thoughts while being drawn into interactions initiated by other characters. Conversations unfold through dialogue choices under social pressure, with key moments shaped by how the player responds to harassment, perceived kindness, and skepticism from others. Player agency is deliberately constrained through lack of combat, sprinting, and a traditional inventory system. These intentional limitations reinforce the themes of vulnerability and entrapment that define the protagonist's psychological state.

Narrative progression is shaped by social decisions rather than skill mastery. Players must interpret ambiguous social cues, decide whom to trust, and choose how to respond under pressure. These choices lead to branching outcomes, including abduction, escape accompanied by disbelief, or unresolved ambiguity. Even when danger appears to be confirmed, the game intentionally undermines certainty, positioning Ashley as an unreliable narrator whose fears are constantly questioned by others.

Visually and structurally, Paranoia adopts a PSX-inspired aesthetic with low-poly models, jitter, and analog distortion. The style anchors the game in its time period while mirroring psychological instability and the imperfect nature of memory and perception. This results in an intimate, unsettling experience that frames horror as something plausibly happening in an ordinary place, to an ordinary person, just out of sight.

1.3 Target Audience

The target audience consists of players who enjoy narrative-focused horror experiences, particularly fans of PSX-inspired indie titles such as Fears to Fathom and games by Chilla's Art. The game appeals to players interested in psychological tension, social realism, and emotionally heavy storytelling rather than action or spectacle. While Paranoia contains no gore or explicit blood, due to its mature themes (i.e., harassment, manipulation, panic attacks, implied CSA, and kidnapping), the game is intended for players aged 15 and up who are comfortable engaging with disturbing subject matters.

1.4 Target Platforms

Paranoia is designed primarily for PC (Windows), using mouse and keyboard controls to support precise interaction, dialogue selection, and panic mechanics. The game's scope, control scheme, and visual style are optimized for desktop play with potential for future expansion to other PC-compatible platforms if required.

1.5 Competitive Positioning

Paranoia differentiates itself within the psychological horror genre by shifting the source of fear from external threats to internal interpretation and social ambiguity. Rather than relying on explicit danger, the experience is built around situations that remain plausible, deniable, and socially grounded, forcing the player to question whether perceived threats are real or misinterpreted.

In comparable titles within the genre, horror is often conveyed through a progression from normalcy to explicit danger where the player is gradually led toward a moment of confirmation. Suspense is built through environmental cues, scripted events, and the expectation that a hidden threat will eventually reveal itself in a concrete form.

Paranoia adopts the structural foundation of this genre but diverges in its treatment of tension and resolution. Instead of progressing toward clear confirmation, the game sustains horror through persistent ambiguity. Threats remain socially plausible and interpretable rather than definitively revealed, shifting the focus from discovering danger to questioning whether it exists at all.

Consequently, Paranoia occupies a distinct position within first-person psychological horror by prioritizing interpretation over revelation as its main conflict. The experience is designed not around surviving a known danger, but around enduring uncertainty and the consequences of being unable to fully trust one's own perception.

Gameplay

2.1 Game Loops

Paranoia is structured around a layered loop system where a high-level psychological loop governs multiple smaller, moment-to-moment gameplay loops. These loops are asymmetric by design as they privilege tension accumulation over release and emphasize negative feedback to prevent power fantasy or mastery.

The macro loop reinforces the core theme that threat is rarely confirmed while stress is always real. Each pass through the loop increases doubt while decreasing certainty. Additionally, micro loops operate continuously inside the main psychological loop.

This game loop structure is designed to:

- Maintain psychological pressure without combat
- Replace mastery with vigilance
- Use negative feedback to prevent empowerment
- Align player behavior with Ashley's mental state

By prioritizing regulation over reward, Paranoia transforms familiar game loops into tools for psychological horror grounded in social realism.

2.1.1 Main Psychological Loop

"Observe → Interpret → Face Threat → Regulate → Re-engage"

1. The player encounters a mundane situation or social interaction.
2. Ambiguous cues trigger interpretation through Ashley's subjective perception.
3. Perceived threat decreases Composure by increasing psychological pressure.
4. The player must regulate stress to maintain agency.
5. Composure is restored, returning the player to observation under heightened sensitivity.

2.1.2 Core Gameplay Loops

a. **Inspection (Exploration & Interpretation)**

"Look → Highlighted Object → Inspect → Inner Monologue → Contextual Meaning"

1. Functions as a curiosity-driven loop
2. Provides narrative insight rather than mechanical reward
3. Often decreases Composure, acting as a negative feedback cost for knowledge

b. **Interaction (Commitment)**

"Look → Highlighted Object → Interact → Commit → Action Resolves"

1. Reinforces intentionality and irreversibility
2. No optimization or inventory gain
3. Keeps the player grounded in physical, mundane tasks

c. **Social Pressure & Choice**

"Setup → Dialogue Trigger → Choice Under Pressure → Social Outcome"

1. Choices affect tone, trust, and perceived safety rather than stats
2. Outcomes are often ambiguous
3. Prioritizes emotional consequence over clarity

d. **Panic Management**

"Stress Trigger → Breathing Sequence → Success or Failure → Control or Reset"

1. Acts as a regulation gate, not a punishment
2. Failure temporarily removes agency
3. Success restores partial Composure but never fully resets tension

2.1.3 Feedback Loops

Paranoia primarily employs negative feedback loops with limited, localized positive feedback. While the negative feedback loops prevent escalation into mastery and mirror real anxiety spirals, positive feedback is temporary and fragile, never allowing the player to snowball into safety or dominance. In every negative feedback loop, the game pushes back as the player becomes overwhelmed.

Overall, the game loop structure is designed to:

- Maintain psychological pressure without combat
- Replace mastery with vigilance
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a. **Negative Feedback Loops (Dominant)**

1. Decreasing Composure increases visual/audio distortion
2. Distortion makes interactions harder to parse
3. Poor parsing decreases Composure further
4. Panic interrupts play, forcing regulation

b. **Positive Feedback Loops (Restricted)**

1. Successful panic regulation restores limited Composure
2. Choosing safe or avoidant dialogue options reduces immediate exposure
3. Creating distance from stressful situations slows Composure loss

2.1.4 Loop Stacking

Unlike traditional games, loops do not resolve cleanly; they recur with variation, reinforcing doubt without allowing the opportunity to have closure. Paranoia stacks loops across scales:

1. **Core Loop (seconds-to-seconds):**
   Breathing, dialogue responses, inspections
2. **Scene Loop (minutes):**
   Exploration → confrontation → regulation → relief
3. **Narrative Loop (act-level):**
   Threat implied → denied → partially confirmed → re-framed

2.2 Objectives

a. **Macro**

1. Survive Ashley's shift and post-shift interaction(s) without being taken
2. Navigate social threats while maintaining sufficient Composure
3. Reach one of the narrative conclusions:
   - Taken (bad end)
   - Escaped but disbelieved (ambiguous)

b. **Micro (per segment)**

1. Perform cashier duties.
2. Complete grocery tasks / inspections to understand Ashley.
3. Maintain Composure under stress
4. Manage dialogue with Obnoxious Guy and Charming Guy.
5. Make key decisions: accept/decline escort, choose how to talk to Skylar, etc.

2.3 Game Progression

1. **Training Level** (Register → Aisle → First Flashback)

Establishes routine, constrained agency, and introduces panic management through the first breathing sequence.

2. **Grocery Shopping** (Store interior → Panic management → End of shopping)

Introduces dynamic encounters and composure-driven variation in interaction outcomes.

3. **Main Grocery Run** (Queue → Charming Guy → Checkout)

Introduces the primary social threats and tests the player's ability to interpret ambiguous intent under pressure.

4. **Good Samaritan Decision** (Exit)
   - **Leave Route (Bad Ending):** Parking lot → panel van reveal → Obnoxious Guy confirmed → abduction cut to black.
   - **Stay Route (Main Route):** Bench wait → pager exchange → van observation → Skylar pickup.
5. **Car Ride** (Debrief)

The player shapes how events are described; Skylar challenges Ashley's reliability and interpretation.

6. **Therapy** (Time Skip / Aftermath)

Ashley is framed through external perspectives (Skylar + therapist). A newspaper provides partial confirmation, while the therapist's framing preserves ambiguity over whether the threat was real or perceived.

2.4 Play Flow

1. **Title Screen –** Main Menu: Play Demo, How to Play, Settings, Exit.
2. **Low Stakes Routine** – Cash register tutorial; time pressure is light, tone mundane.
3. **Mild Unease** – Post-shift shopping: slow exploration, internalized loneliness & anxiety.
4. **Confrontation** – Rude customer, control removed → flashback → first Breathing challenge.
5. **Relief** – Co-worker intervention; tutorial arc ends.

6. **Dynamic Pressure** – Exploration level with repeated composure-driven encounters.
7. **Main Threat Setup** – Store queue: Obnoxious Guy intro → insults → Breathing challenge.
8. **False Safety** – Charming Guy "rescues" Ashley; light banter.
9. **Decision Path**:
    - Escort route → slow-burn dread → reveal → hard cut.
    - Stay route → subtle visual cue fades when he leaves → pager & van observation.
10. **Reflection** – Car ride with Skylar: player-voiced version of events.
11. **Doubt** – Therapy office: Skylar + therapist narrate Ashley as unreliable.
12. **Twist** – Newspaper article confirms modus operandi of two-man van scheme; therapist's question undercuts it.
13. **Final Panic** – Ashley hyperventilates; credits over uncertainty.

2.5 Challenge Structure

Challenge is grounded in psychological pressure instead of combat.

- **Mechanical Difficulty**: concentrated into Breathing sequences requiring sustained input.
- **Cognitive Difficulty**: reading social cues, evaluating trust, parsing incomplete information.
- **Emotional Difficulty**: discomfort in dialogue, being dismissed, morally gray choices.
    - **Failure =** panic collapse or bad narrative ending. Breathing segments reset locally.

Mechanics & Systems

3.1 Mechanics, Dynamics & Aesthetics (MDA)

Paranoia applies the "Mechanics, Dynamics & Aesthetics" (MDA) framework to ensure that psychological tension emerges from player interaction rather than narrative

exposition alone. The game's mechanics are designed around restriction, subjectivity, and deliberate commitment, shaping how players move, observe, respond, and cope within ordinary social spaces.

These mechanics give rise to dynamics of hesitation, vigilance, and self-doubt. Restricted movement and grounded interaction slow the player's pace and encourage careful observation rather than impulsive action. Inspection mechanics draw attention to mundane objects, producing reflective play driven by internal interpretation instead of external rewards. Dialogue systems place the player under social pressure, generating uncertainty about how to respond and whether asserting boundaries will escalate or resolve tension. Panic management intermittently disrupts control, reinforcing cycles of stability and collapse that condition players to anticipate anxiety even in non-threatening moments.

Together, these dynamics produce an aesthetic of psychological discomfort grounded in plausibility. The player experiences anxiety through loss of agency, paranoia through ambiguous social cues, and vulnerability through sustained uncertainty rather than explicit threat. By linking restrictive mechanics to dynamics of interpretation and emotional regulation, Paranoia uses the MDA framework to translate internal psychological stress into an interactive experience that is felt through play rather than explained through story.

3.2 Game Systems

3.2.1 Movement

Movement and camera behavior are tuned to support vulnerability. Ashley's base walk speed is modest and cannot be increased; there is no sprint or jump. In certain scenes, movement is deliberately constrained and, in full dialogue or panic sequences, all locomotion is locked. In these constrained segments she is fixed to a spot with head rotation limited to a defined arc, keeping the player anchored to a counter, queue position, or chair. These limits are physically consistent and clearly implied by the environment, and the player is expected to read the restriction itself as narrative: Ashley at work, stuck in line, dissociating, or frozen by anxiety.

3.2.2 Inspection & Interaction

For both inspection and interaction, a central crosshair defines Ashley's focus. When it rests on an interactable object within range, the object emits a yellow emission, a concise on-screen prompt appears, and a brief click sound confirms selection. Only objects surfaced this way can be used; there is no hidden pixel-hunting. Ranges are physically

grounded as the player must be within arm's reach and roughly facing the object for the prompt to appear. This prevents snapping to distant targets, preserves the sense of handling real-world space, and reinforces that Ashley only engages with what is close enough to consciously notice.

3.2.2.1 Inspection

Inspection interactions reveal Ashley's inner monologue. Selecting an inspectable object opens a text box containing her thoughts, styled in italics to distinguish them from spoken dialogue. As long as the player keeps the object in view, the text remains; looking away closes it instantly, emphasizing that these thoughts are momentary and stimulus-bound. Some objects support a second inspection, offering a deeper or more uncomfortable thought if the player persists.

3.2.2.2 Interaction

Interaction is always explicit and intentional. The UI prompts for interactable objects change depending on the action (e.g. "Ring", "Collect", "Read"). Once committed, the action resolves reliably and may advance the scene, branch dialogue, or subtly adjust tension. Instances are listed below.

- Processing customer items at the register → "Ring" (Training Level)
- Bagging purchased groceries at checkout → "Collect" (Store Queue)
- Committing to remaining in the store or leaving with Charming Guy → "Stay" or "Leave" (Good Samaritan)
- Picking up and reading newspaper in the therapist's office → "Read" (Therapy)

3.2.3 Dialogue

When a conversation begins, free movement is suspended and a dialogue interface appears. If no choices are available, the player advances text manually, ensuring full control over pacing. When choices are present, they are selected and confirmed through cursor input, influencing tone, relationship dynamics, and narrative direction.

Ashley's spoken dialogue is presented as standard text, while her internal reactions remain italicized, preserving the distinction between expression and suppression.

Composure directly affects dialogue clarity and availability. At stable levels, conversations proceed normally with full response options. As composure decreases, dialogue may become distorted, reinterpretations may appear, and response options may

be reduced or removed entirely, resulting in forced silence. This alters both the duration and outcome of interactions, as NPCs react to Ashley's inability to respond appropriately.

3.2.3.1 Dialogue Example

Skylar: Did you get all your bags?

Ashley: Not like I had much to buy.

(Skylar gives Ashley a look.)[1]

Ashley: Yeah. I got everything.

(Beat.)

Skylar: So. What happened?

Player choices:

A. What do you mean?

B. There was this guy…

C. I felt sick.

Choice A – What do you mean?

Ashley: What do you mean?

Skylar: You paged me to leave work early and drive across town. So, I'm asking… /n[2] …what… /n …happened.

Ashley: I'm… sorry.

(Skylar glances at Ashley.)

Skylar: … n/ It's fine. I just wanted to know if you're sick, something happened at work, or whatever. You know I'll come get you regardless.

Player choices:

A. *Tell Skylar what happened* → go to Choice B – There was this guy…

B. *Make up an excuse* → go to Choice C – I felt sick.

Choice B – There was this guy…

Ashley: There was this guy.

Skylar: Of course.

[1] Parentheses denote actions or beats during which the dialogue text box temporarily disappears.
[2] "/n" denotes that the following text is displayed in a new text box in-game.

Ashley: I was in line and he went /n “I LIKE YOUR HAIR!” n/ F*cking embarrassing. Then he started insulting me out of nowhere. Going about me being a bitch and all that.

Skylar: F*cking dick.

(Skylar slaps the steering wheel with the bottom of her palm.)

Skylar: I swear, half these guys should be on leashes. n/ What happened after?

Player choices:

A. Then this other guy…

B. I paged you.

B1 – Then this other guy…

Ashley: Then this other guy stepped in. Told him to back off. He actually left.

Skylar: Good. Ashley: And then the other guy offered to walk me out. To the bus stop. He was… nice.

(Beat.)

Ashley: I said yes. Then I got this feeling and told him never mind.

(Skylar glances at her.)

Skylar: Well… I get you’d be jumpy after the first creep. But I mean…

Ashley: What? Skylar: You get a ‘gut feeling’ about every guy, Ash. I never know when it’s intuition talking or… /n your paranoia.

(Beat.)

Ashley: It wasn’t paranoia. I saw him walk to this van. Someone else was waiting in the driver’s seat. That’s- that’s weird, right?

Skylar: So what? Bus stop’s a five-minute walk from there. Maybe his ride was picking him up. Maybe it’s his carpool. Not every van is a kidnapping.

Player choices:

A. *Argue*

B. *Accept*

B1a – *Argue*

Ashley: But-

Skylar: Ash, can we not do that right now? We’ll talk at home.

Ashley: Okay. Fine. Sorry.

(Dialogue ends.)

B1b – Accept

Ashley: … /n Yeah. Maybe I just… freaked myself out.

Skylar: There you go.

(Dialogue ends.)

B2 – I paged you.

Ashley: I paged you.

Skylar: I know that part.

(Beat.)

Skylar: I'm asking what happened before that. Like, did you just turn away and page me?

Ashley: I... He… The cashier told him not to hold the line and I paged you while she ranged me. It was either that or… black out. I couldn't breathe.

Skylar: Okay. Then you did the right thing.

Choice C – I felt sick.

Ashley: I felt sick. Like, nauseous. Couldn't take the bus.

Skylar: Well, do you feel better now?

Ashley: …I guess.

Skylar: You know, a therapist could help with that as well.

Ashley: With what?

Skylar: The panic. The food thing. You don't eat meat, fine. Triggering or whatever. But you don't eat much of anything either.

Ashley: …

Skylar: You can't 'not be hungry' every day. That's not how bodies work.

Ashley: Can we not do this right now? I really don't feel well.

Skylar: Fine. Starve yourself. See how that works out.

3.2.4 Panic Management

Panic sequences translate Ashley's anxiety into an active regulation mechanic. When triggered, the player's focus narrows through visual and audio changes, and a "Breathe" prompt appears alongside a focus bar representing controlled breathing.

The player must repeatedly input actions to stabilize the bar. Maintaining rhythm allows progress, while hesitation or interruption causes regression. This creates a direct mechanical link between input consistency and psychological regulation.

Successful completion restores partial composure and returns control to the player, though stability is never fully regained. Failure results in a brief loss of consciousness and a localized reset, reinforcing the cost of failing to regulate stress without fully halting progression.

These sequences are triggered both through scripted moments and through composure breakdown during gameplay, ensuring that panic emerges as a consequence of sustained pressure rather than isolated events.

3.3 Game Physics

The environment relies on simple, readable collision systems that prioritize clarity over complexity. Physical elements such as shelves, counters, barriers, and NPCs define movement boundaries, eliminating the need for invisible walls. Spatial design guides the player naturally through constrained areas such as aisles and queues, reinforcing controlled movement without explicit restriction.

The player cannot pass through other characters, ensuring that proximity and positioning contribute to social pressure. Being physically blocked or confined within shared spaces reinforces the feeling of limited escape and sustained exposure.

Time operates consistently at the simulation level, with animations, ambient systems, and NPC behaviors running at normal speed. During panic or flashback sequences, perceived time is altered through audiovisual distortion rather than changes to the underlying system. The world continues to function normally while Ashley's perception becomes unreliable, reinforcing the distinction between external reality and internal experience.

3.4 Player Controls

- WASD – Move
- Mouse – Look
- LMB – Interact / advance text / confirm

- ESC – Pause menu, settings

Crosshair visible in free-movement segments; hidden or repurposed in cinematics.

Game Economy

4.1 Core Resource

Composure represents Ashley's psychological stability and her ability to accurately perceive, interpret, and respond to social and environmental stimuli. Unlike traditional health systems, composure does not reflect physical damage, but cumulative mental strain. It functions as a continuously active resource that directly determines player agency, interaction quality, and perceptual clarity.

Composure is displayed as an omnipresent UI bar, remaining visible across all gameplay segments to reinforce constant psychological pressure. The system functions as:

- A resource economy, not a punishment system
- A pacing controller that discourages rapid, exhaustive interaction
- A psychological analogue to health systems without physical violence

Making Composure omnipresent and slow to recover positions stress as a persistent, accumulating presence that is subtle yet enduring, and ultimately something to cope with rather than resolve.

4.1.1 Composure Values & Thresholds

- **Range:** 0–100
- **Stable Zone:** 80–100
- **Deterioration Zone:** 40–80
- **Breakdown Zone:** 0–40

Composure does not reset between encounters within a level. Instead, it persists and accumulates, reinforcing the idea that stress compounds instead of disappearing instantly. Higher values represent stability and control, while lower values represent loss of clarity, reduced agency, and increased perceptual distortion.

4.2 Accumulation & Recovery Rules

4.2.1 Composure Decrease

Composure decreases through:

- Triggering inspections (objects with distressing internal monologue)
- Social confrontations
- Consecutive stressful interactions without recovery time
- Remaining in confined or socially pressuring spaces

Certain interactions are tagged as High-Impact Triggers, causing faster composure loss when chained together. This creates compounding pressure, where repeated exposure without regulation leads to rapid deterioration rather than linear decline.

4.2.2 Composure Recovery

Composure naturally recovers over time when the player is given space:

- Avoiding interaction
- Moving through low-pressure areas
- After completing a successful breathing sequence

Recovery is intentionally slower than accumulation to discourage brute-force play and promote pacing. The system ensures that composure cannot be fully restored through passive waiting alone, requiring the player to balance engagement and regulation.

4.2.3 Threshold Effects & Feedback

a. **Deterioration Zone (40–80)**

- Subtle screen noise
- Mild chromatic aberration
- Slight audio dampening
- Faster Composure gain from new triggers
- Dialogue tone begins to shift or distort

This zone signals rising instability while maintaining player control, introducing early-stage perceptual unreliability without removing agency.

b. **Breakdown Zone (80–100)**

- Heavy visual distortion
- Vignette tightening
- Increased breathing audio
- Input latency during interactions
- Dialogue distortion and reduced player response options

Crossing into this zone arms a panic trigger, meaning the next qualifying stressor will initiate a breathing sequence. At this stage, perception becomes unreliable and social interaction begins to fail due to reduced agency.

Visually, this mirrors traditional health systems where danger is communicated through audiovisual degradation rather than numeric failure.

4.3 Breathing Mechanic Integration

4.3.1 Trigger Conditions

During free-play segments where the player moves without immediate narrative constraints, breathing sequences function as regulation checks rather than binary fail states, contrasting with their role in scripted encounters.

Overall, they can be triggered in three ways:

1. Scripted narrative moments
2. Entering the Breakdown Zone and encountering an additional stressor
3. Forced early triggers during training scenarios

4.3.2 Difficulty Scaling

- **Training Breathing Sequences**: Triggered earlier, easier to complete, and recover less Composure
- **Standard Breathing Sequences**: Triggered at high Composure, require sustained input, restore more Composure

Failure results in a brief dissociative collapse and scene reset, reinforcing the cost of poor regulation.

4.3.3 Training Level Application

During the training section, Composure is intentionally tuned to be volatile:

- Triggering inspections increase Composure faster than it can decay

- Early breathing sequences are triggered at lower thresholds
- Visual distortion appears sooner but fades faster

This teaches the player that internal thoughts are mechanically dangerous, stress is not tied only to overt threats and that regulation is an active skill, not a passive state.

Story & Narrative

5.1 Narrative Intention

Paranoia is designed as a psychological horror game that explores fear, perception, and the social consequences of being wrong or worse, being right.

There are no monsters to defeat and no clear villains to expose. The danger is ordinary, socially acceptable, and difficult to name. It appears as a compliment, a helpful gesture, a calm voice offering reassurance. Nothing is overtly wrong, yet something never fully feels right.

The tension does not revolve around whether a threat exists. It revolves around whether Ashley can trust herself when that threat cannot be immediately proven. Every interaction forces her to choose between instinct and social harmony, between discomfort and the fear of being mistaken.

What begins as an attempt to leave safely becomes something more corrosive. Ashley has been conditioned to soften her reactions, to reinterpret unease as misunderstanding, to doubt her body before she doubts others. The deeper conflict lies in whether she can resist that reflex.

The story avoids clean resolution. Even when danger is confirmed, relief is complicated. Even when danger is avoided, doubt remains. Certainty never arrives without consequence.

At its core, Paranoia is about the cost of self-erasure. Fear can be endured. Losing faith in your own perception is far more dangerous.

5.1.1 Core Themes

- Perception of Reality
- Fear & Isolation
- Trust in Oneself
- Self-Erasure

- Power Imbalance

5.2 The Three-Act Structure

5.2.1 Act I – The Ordinary

a) Exposition

Ashley finishes her shift behind the cash register, moving through repetitive tasks under harsh fluorescent lighting. Behind the counter, the store feels safe. Customers approach, transact, and leave, and her role provides a clear structure for interaction.

Once her shift ends, she remains in uniform and begins shopping. Without the barrier of the counter, the space feels subtly different. It's more open. More exposed… Her groceries reflect routine rather than care, and she avoids certain sections without fully questioning why. Ashley seeks stability above all else, believing that by staying agreeable and unremarkable, she can prevent situations from escalating.

b) Inciting Incident

Near the end of an aisle, a regular customer approaches and asks for help, assuming she is still working. She explains that her shift has ended, expecting the interaction to resolve, but it does not. His tone shifts from polite to irritated, his presence becoming just uncomfortable enough to feel wrong without clearly justifying confrontation.

Ashley hesitates. Asserting herself would require certainty; escalating would require proof. Instead, she softens her response and apologizes. As the interaction stretches, her perception begins to fracture. Her breathing shortens, the environment tightens, and a familiar unease intrudes. Before the moment fully escalates, a co-worker intervenes and the situation dissolves. To anyone else, it was insignificant. For Ashley, it lingers.

c) Plot Point One

Ashley has the option to leave the store immediately, but instead chooses to stay. Instead of moving directly to checkout, she lingers in the aisles, continuing to shop without urgency. The store remains unchanged, but without the counter, there is no structure guiding her movement or interaction.

She moves between shelves, picking up items, putting them back, avoiding certain areas where other customers are present. The longer she stays, the less defined her purpose becomes. Nothing explicitly happens, yet the sense of exposure persists, subtle but present.

Eventually, she joins the checkout line as a customer. With movement now constrained and no role to fall back on, she is left fully within the space rather than observing it. The environment remains the same, but her position within it has shifted; and with it, her sense of safety.

5.2.2 Act II - Escalation

a) Rising Action

While waiting in line, Ashley becomes the focus of another man whose behavior escalates from intrusive attention to hostility. The interaction remains socially ambiguous, but the public setting traps her in place, increasing pressure. When she does not reciprocate, his tone turns accusatory, drawing attention from others.

Another man intervenes, presenting himself as calm and considerate, causing the first to withdraw. The situation appears resolved, but the sense of safety is unstable. The threat divides into two forms: one overt and aggressive, the other subtle and controlled. The second man offers to help and suggests walking her out, framing his behavior as reasonable and safe.

b) Midpoint

If Ashley accepts, the encounter continues into the parking lot, where the environment remains outwardly ordinary while the path gradually shifts away from safety. A white van comes into view, and the earlier aggressor reappears, revealing coordination.

If she refuses, she later observes the same connection from inside the store, watching the two men leave together. In both cases, the illusion of safety collapses. Being wrong carries social consequences, but being right carries physical risk.

c) Plot Point Two

During the car ride with Skylar, Ashley must recount the event. Her experience is questioned, reframed, and partially dismissed, shifting the conflict away from the external threat and toward her own interpretation.

Ashley must decide how much of the event to disclose and how to frame it. Was it a coincidence, or something coordinated? Was it fear, or pattern recognition? Up until now, she has survived by minimizing her experiences. In this moment, she is forced to decide whether to continue doing so.

5.2.3 Act III - Resolution

If Ashley left with the guy, the story ends in the parking lot. The van door opens, and the screen cuts to black.

If she stayed in the grocery story, the confrontation shifts inward.

a) Pre-Climax

In the therapist's office, Ashley's experience is interpreted through the perspectives of others. Skylar and the therapist frame her reactions through anxiety and past trauma, subtly undermining her certainty. The threat is no longer defined by the event itself, but by the ambiguity surrounding it.

b) Climax

The story concludes without resolution. The threat may have been real, but certainty is never fully achieved. The absence of immediate danger does not restore safety; instead, it leaves Ashley in a state where both interpretations coexist. Doubt lingers, unresolved, even in silence.

c) Denouement

The session ends without breakthrough. Outside, the night is still. No vans idle at the curb, no footsteps trail behind her… The world presents no immediate threat.

Ashley sits alone in Skylar's apartment, the silence heavier than the noise ever was. The kidnapping scheme was real. Her trauma is real. Both can exist, yet neither resolves the other. Certainty does not arrive, and it never fully does.

She does not apologize for what she felt, nor does she retract what she saw. Still, doubt remains. It's quiet, persistent, and unresolved. For the first time, she cannot tell whether the absence of danger is safety, or simply a pause.

5.3 Backstory

Ashley grew up under a manipulative, abusive male authority figure, leaving her with unresolved trauma and a constant low-level sense of threat. As an adult, she maintains a functional but hollow routine, living in a cheap apartment and working at a local grocery store. Skylar, her high-achieving friend, supports her but is exhausted by the emotional weight. Ashley's anxiety leaks into avoidance of men, disordered eating, and a sharp panic whenever she feels watched, cornered, or "rude" for rejecting advances.

5.4 Characters

1. **Ashley**

   Playable protagonist. Store worker in her mid-20s. Quiet, hypervigilant, clever but self-erasing. Her inner thoughts are articulate while her spoken lines are hesitant and timid. Her disrupted perception of reality is visually mirrored in the world through glitches and vignettes.

2. **Skylar**

   Ashley's best friend. Financial analyst in her mid-20's. Assertive, pragmatic, over-functioning. Loves Ashley but communicates in ultimatums and fixes. Reads as both protective and controlling. Brushes off Ashley's anxiety as paranoia and pushes her to get professional treatment.

3. **Obnoxious Guy**

   Main antagonist. In his late 30s. Loud, entitled, self-proclaimed "nice guy." Knows no boundaries and uses the whole store as his stage. Represents obvious danger.

4. **Charming Guy**

   Passer-by who intervenes. In his late 20s. Soft-spoken and attentive, portrays himself as a genuine gentleman. Represents ambiguous danger; visually clean and polite, but framed with subtle depravity.

5. **Rude Customer**

   Middle-aged regular who misreads Ashley's uniform and pushes past her boundaries to receive servility. His mundane hostility triggers disproportionate panic for Ashley.

6. **Store Employee**

   Co-worker who cuts in briefly to confirm Ashley is off the clock and deescalate the situation with Rude Customer. A decent interaction that forces the player to question whether every man is a threat, or filtered through Ashley's fear.

7. **Therapist**

   Male CBT therapist booked by Skylar. In Ashley's eyes, he's positioned between genuine help and institutional gaslighting. His clinical questioning in

the wake of the incident risks reframing Ashley's fear as pathology rather than response.

5.3 Plot Elements

5.3.1 World-Building

Ashley's surroundings and inner dialogue subtly reveal her mental state, personal history and the era she inhabits.

Store Items:

- Microwave Chilli → Low-care self-maintenance; burnout and neglect.
- Meat → Has an eating disorder connected to trauma of abuse
- Beer → Medicalized anxiety; suggests history of panic attacks.
- Chips → Lives alone / no shared domestic life + defensive "at least I don't have to share" = loneliness masked as choice.

Era Indicators (late 1990s):

- Manual Cash Register → Lacks a barcode scanner, requiring Ashley to input prices manually; emphasizes the pre-digital retail world.
- Pager → Replaces a cell phone; symbolizes limited connectivity and signals Ashley's lower-income status.
- Car Radio → Has the distinct 90s analog sound quality, playing contemporary pop hits.

Pager Codes:

- 91120 → 911 = "Call back now", 20 = "Where are you"; together implies "pick me up now"
- 104 → "Okay/Affirmative"

5.3.2 Character-Centric Symbolism

- Restricted movement during selected scenes → A visual metaphor for habitual vigilance without power. Frames Ashley's lack of agency in a situation she is physically and psychologically confined.
- Charming Guy helping bag groceries → Performs tenderness, mirrors predator grooming.
- Chromatic aberration around Charming Guy → Visualized intuition that something's off.

- Skylar minimizing gut feeling → Reinforces theme that no one takes Ashley perception fully seriously.
- Therapist office with Skylar oversharing → Institutional gaze on Ashley's trauma; she's objectified even in "help."

5.3.3 Flashback(s)

- Overlapping present environment & flashback → Blurred reality; Ashley's emotional truth is intrusive and inescapable, regardless of setting.
- Hyperventilation vignette / focus shifts → Somatic horror; body hijacks control.
- Larger man, reaching camera → Power imbalance, grooming, bodily threat.

5.3.4 Interface

- Dialogue options shrinking to "…" → Mechanically enforces Ashley silencing.
- Breathing sequence text "Breathe" → Ashley's brain going into survival mode, hyper fixated on one vital thing.

Levels

6.1 Level Layout

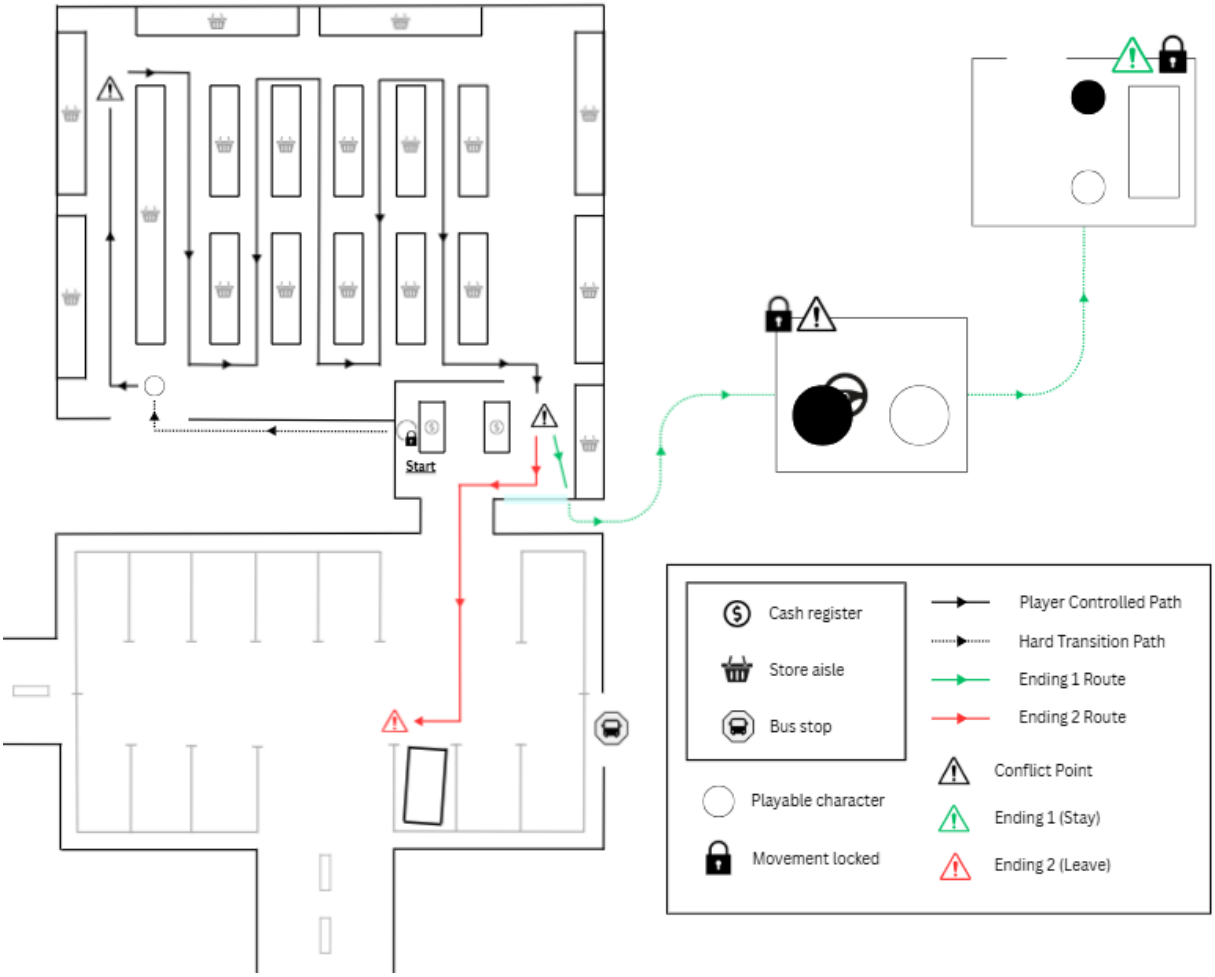


Figure 1. *Diagram showing player spawns, movement restrictions, conflict points, and branching routes leading to different narrative outcomes.*

6.2.1 Training Level

The Training Level introduces the player to the core interaction systems in a controlled environment where composure remains largely stable. The player begins at the cash register, performing simple interaction tasks that establish basic input, timing, and feedback loops. Movement is initially constrained, reinforcing routine and predictability before transitioning into limited free exploration within the store.

After being released from the register, the player navigates the aisles and engages in low-risk inspection interactions. These actions provide narrative context through inner monologue while familiarizing the player with object-based interaction systems.

Composure begins to fluctuate slightly during this phase but remains within a stable range, ensuring that perception and dialogue are not significantly altered.

A single NPC interaction is introduced to demonstrate escalation. The encounter is structured to gradually increase pressure, with composure decreasing in response to sustained discomfort. Dialogue remains mostly readable, though minor distortion may occur if composure drops. The interaction culminates in a controlled panic sequence, introducing the breathing mechanic in a guided format. This sequence ensures that the player understands how composure loss interrupts gameplay and how regulation restores partial control. The level concludes once the player successfully completes this loop, establishing the foundational cycle of interaction, pressure, composure loss, and recovery.

6.2.2 Grocery Shopping

This level removes structured guidance and shifts gameplay into a system-driven state where composure actively determines the player's experience. The environment is reconfigured into a semi-navigable space with no direct path to progression, preventing immediate access to the register and forcing the player to remain within the environment. Movement is unrestricted within defined boundaries, but progression is delayed through spatial design rather than explicit barriers.

The player can freely explore and inspect objects, but these actions no longer serve as neutral interactions. Instead, they contribute to pacing and influence composure indirectly by increasing exposure to potential interruptions. NPC encounters are triggered dynamically based on player behavior, including time spent idle, repeated inspection actions, and presence within certain zones. NPCs do not follow fixed paths and may initiate interaction from multiple directions, including blind spots or sudden proximity, creating unpredictability without relying on scripted events.

Composure directly determines how each interaction unfolds. At higher levels, dialogue remains stable and interactions proceed normally, allowing full player agency. As composure decreases into a mid–low range, perception begins to deteriorate. Environmental elements subtly merge with memory fragments, and dialogue may shift in tone, reinterpreting neutral interactions as negative or intrusive. At low composure levels, dialogue becomes heavily distorted and player responses collapse into silence, represented by non-interactive dialogue options. This removal of agency shortens interactions and alters NPC behavior, often causing them to disengage or react with discomfort or irritation.

Panic sequences are triggered conditionally rather than at fixed points. If an NPC persists during interaction, the breathing sequence may begin mid-dialogue, interrupting the

exchange. If the NPC disengages, the sequence may trigger immediately after the interaction ends. This ensures that panic is tied to social pressure rather than scripted timing.

Flashbacks are also context-dependent and occur as brief interruptions following interaction outcomes. Encounters that end in disengagement trigger memories associated with rejection and isolation, while aggressive interactions trigger memories tied to control and suppression. These sequences are short and return control quickly, functioning as feedback rather than extended cutscenes.

This level establishes the core gameplay identity by demonstrating that instability is systemic rather than scripted. Player experience varies based on composure management, interaction choices, and environmental exposure, reinforcing uncertainty and preventing predictable outcomes.

6.2.3 Store Queue

The Store Queue level restricts player movement and concentrates all gameplay into sustained social interaction. The player is confined within a fixed position in line, removing the ability to disengage or reposition. This spatial limitation increases baseline pressure and accelerates composure decay over time.

A primary NPC initiates an unavoidable interaction that escalates regardless of player input. Composure determines how the interaction is perceived and how effectively the player can respond. At higher composure, the exchange remains uncomfortable but manageable. At lower composure, dialogue distortion intensifies and response options become limited or unavailable, increasing the likelihood of failed interaction outcomes.

If composure drops significantly, panic may trigger during the interaction, interrupting player control. Successful regulation may allow the interaction to resolve externally through the intervention of a secondary NPC, introducing a temporary sense of stability. However, this resolution does not restore full composure, maintaining tension beyond the immediate encounter.

The level reinforces the effect of confinement by combining restricted movement with continuous social pressure, ensuring that composure loss feels inevitable rather than avoidable.

6.2.4 Good Samaritan

This level functions as a transition point where player choice determines progression. The player engages in a dialogue-based decision influenced by prior interactions and current

composure level. While the mechanical input remains simple, the perceived safety of each option is affected by composure, altering how the situation is interpreted rather than changing the structure of the choice itself.

This moment does not introduce new mechanics but serves as a convergence of prior systems, requiring the player to act under uncertainty. The outcome branches into separate sequences, with composure continuing to influence perception and interaction in both paths.

a) Leave (Bad Ending)

If Ashley chooses to leave with Charming Guy (Secondary NPC), the level transitions into the parking lot. Movement remains guided, with the player following him along a natural path away from the store. The interaction continues without immediate escalation, maintaining the tone established during the previous encounter.

The path gradually shifts away from the expected route under a plausible pretext, reducing the player's ability to reassess the situation. As a white panel van comes into view, the encounter resolves quickly. Obnoxious Guy (Primary NPC) is revealed inside, confirming the connection between the two characters.

At this point, player control is removed and the sequence concludes immediately. The outcome is abrupt and final, providing confirmation of the threat without extending interaction or allowing recovery.

b) Stay (Main Route)

If Ashley chooses to remain in the store, the level shifts into a low-intensity waiting state. Movement is limited to a small area near the front, positioning the player to observe the parking lot without direct engagement.

Charming Guy (Secondary NPC) disengages after the refusal, and no further interaction occurs. The player retains control but is no longer exposed to immediate pressure. From this position, the player can observe the Secondary NPC entering a white panel van with the Primary NPC before leaving the area.

This sequence provides indirect confirmation of the threat while maintaining distance from it. A short exchange with Skylar transitions the level forward, ending the segment without confrontation. The outcome reinforces uncertainty by validating suspicion through observation rather than direct experience.

6.2.5 Car Ride

The Car Ride level shifts gameplay into a confined, dialogue-driven environment where composure remains active and continuously influenced by player interaction. Movement is limited to environmental focus and minor interaction points, but these actions contribute to composure regulation.

Dialogue with Skylar becomes the primary mechanic, with composure determining the clarity and availability of player responses. At higher composure, the player can articulate events fully, maintaining control over the narrative. At lower composure, responses become fragmented or absent, leading to misinterpretation and increasing skepticism from the NPC.

Environmental interactions provide subtle composure adjustments, allowing the player to stabilize or destabilize depending on focus. The scene maintains ambiguity by ensuring that NPC reactions adapt to both player input and composure state, reinforcing uncertainty in interpretation.

6.2.6 Therapy (Good Ending)

The Therapy level places the player in a controlled environment where composure is influenced by both interaction and unavoidable triggers. The player has limited agency, with dialogue and inspection serving as the primary forms of engagement.

Composure determines Ashley's ability to participate in the conversation. At lower levels, she may fail to respond or engage, reinforcing external perceptions of instability. NPC dialogue reframes the player's experience through skepticism and interpretation, shifting the conflict away from external threat and toward internal reliability.

Certain interactions override composure stability entirely, forcing a breakdown regardless of prior state. These moments act as narrative anchors, ensuring that key information destabilizes the player consistently. The final sequence maintains composure at a compromised level, preventing full recovery and preserving ambiguity.

The level concludes without resolving the conflict, leaving the player in a state where perception remains unreliable and certainty is unattainable.

Interface, Visuals & Audio

7.1 Menus & Help System

The game includes a Main Menu and Pause Menu. Main menu appears over a static supermarket aisle shot, occasionally interrupted by a brief glitched flash of a fallen basket and spilled items, foreshadowing unease. Options for the main menu are “Play Demo”, “How to Play”, “Settings”, and “Exit”.



Figure 2. *Mockups of the animated* ***Main Menu****, displayed over a static supermarket aisle background. A briefly glitching fallen shopping basket appears intermittently, foreshadowing unease and establishing the game’s tone. Made on Unity.*

Pressing ESC in-game opens a pause menu that freezes gameplay, overlays the scene with a darkened filter, and displays a compact pixelated panel with “Resume”, “Settings”, and “Exit”.

“How to Play” functions as a help system, presenting a concise overview of controls (WASD, mouse look, interact/advance, pause) and core interaction expectations to the player.



Figure 3. *Mockups of the* ***How to Play*** *section, including an overview of player controls and an example sequence explaining the “Breathe” mechanic. Made on Canvas.*

Settings accessed from either menu provide basic configuration, including separate sliders for ambient/world audio and UI/system sounds, using the same visual style as dialogue buttons to maintain consistency.

7.2 Audio, Music & Sound Effects

Audio is predominantly diegetic, low-key, and textured to reinforce the grounded horror tone. Music and sound are used sparingly to track Ashley's stress, guide focus, and blur the line between normalcy and threat.

7.2.1 Diegetic Audio

The supermarket environment is characterized by a persistent layer of mundane, low-level sounds that establish familiarity before being weaponized, such as:

- Constant refrigerator hums
- Distant PA announcements
- HVAC noise
- Flickering fluorescent lights form a sterile acoustic backdrop

At the cash register, multi-key typing loops accompany item processing, remaining distinct from interface clicks to preserve immersion. Three variations of in-store background music provide light, period-appropriate ambience that grows subtly darker and thinner as tension escalates.

During queue and harassment sequences, the same store ambience becomes increasingly oppressive. Background music dulls and thins, while environmental sound gradually muffles, reflecting Ashley's narrowing focus and rising panic as social pressure intensifies.

In the car ride sequence on the stay route, audio shifts to an enclosed, transitional soundscape. The sequence includes:

- Engine noise
- Tires on asphalt
- Passing traffic

These sounds dominate the mix, accompanied by low-volume late-1990s pop music played through a cheap, slightly tinny radio. The familiar sound reinforces a sense of temporary safety while remaining emotionally detached.

The therapist's office contrasts this with quiet institutional stillness. A slow clock tick and faint elevator music bleeding in from the hallway emphasize discomfort, passivity, and the clinical framing of Ashley's experience.

In the parking lot and van sequence on the leave route, audio becomes sparse and exposed. Distant traffic, occasional wildlife, and footsteps on asphalt heighten isolation. This restraint culminates in a sudden, abrupt sequence of sounds:

- The van door opening
- Interior light flicking on
- A brief vocal reaction (i.e. “Ah!”)
- A hard door slam ending the scene.

7.2.2 System & Psychological Audio

System audio is intentionally kept minimal and consistent. A single, subdued UI click is used across interactions, including inspection confirmations and dialogue advancement, ensuring functional clarity without drawing attention away from the environment.

Panic sequences introduce a distinct psychological audio layer. Ambient sound becomes muffled, the stereo field tightens, and heightened breathing and pulse-like swells synchronize with visual vignettes. On failure, a brief distorted audio drop signals collapse before the scene resets, reinforcing the physical and emotional consequences of losing control.

Flashbacks and intuition cues are marked by short, intrusive audio elements such as glitch bursts, filtered noise, and a subtly distorted male laugh. These cues are used sparingly to avoid desensitization, serving as auditory markers of intrusive memory or sensed wrongness rather than explicit threat.

7.3 Art Style

a) Aesthetic Foundation

The visual identity of Paranoia is rooted in PSX-inspired aesthetics, using low poly models with visible seams, stretched UVs, and rough geometry. Textures are hand-painted at low resolution with light dithering, reinforcing a sense of imperfection and instability that aligns with Ashley's fractured perception.

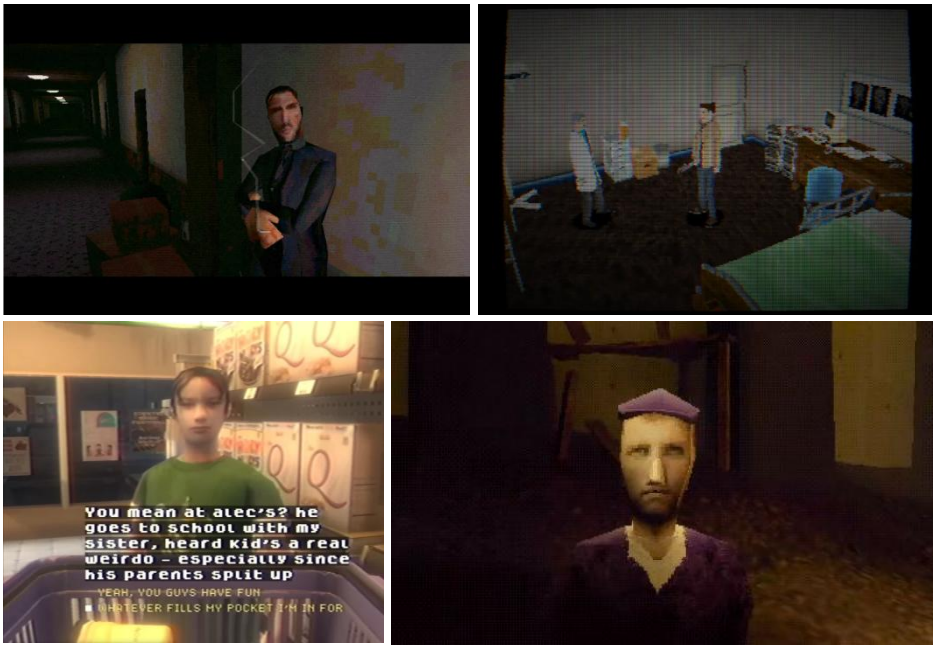


Figure 4. *Visual references shown in order:* ***Nightlink*** *(1998),* ***Back in 1995*** *(2016),* ***Threshold*** *(2022) and* ***Carson House – Fears to Fathom*** *(2021).*

b) Lighting & Atmosphere

Lighting is intentionally harsh and unsettling. Fluorescent overexposure and sharp shadow falloff create a sterile, hostile environment while flat, specular lighting replaces dynamic reflections to heighten artificiality and emotional numbness. The space feels functional rather than comforting, mirroring Ashley's psychological detachment.





*Figure 5. Supermarket scenes shown in order: **The Supermarket Horror** (2021), **Heavy Rain** (2010), **Fears to Fathom – Carson House** (2021), and **Dead of Night: Supermarket** (2022).*

c) Post-Processing & Visual Effects

Post-processing effects are applied with restraint and purpose. Subtle chromatic aberration, screen jitter, and frame instability communicate psychological strain without overwhelming the image. These effects intensify dynamically in response to anxiety, evolving from mild desaturation into temporal blur and peripheral distortion during heightened stress.



Figure 6. Chromatic aberration and screen jitter examples.

d) Color Palette

The color palette is dominated by washed-out beige, gray, and cold white tones that reflect the sterility of the supermarket setting. Warm hues appear briefly during moments of perceived comfort or safety which then fade back into desaturated neutrality as doubt resurfaces.

e) Interface Integration

Interface elements are integrated as narrative devices wherever possible. Traditional HUD elements are replaced by in-world text overlays, flickering signage, and ambient cues, maintaining stylistic and psychological consistency between environment, interface, and narrative experience.

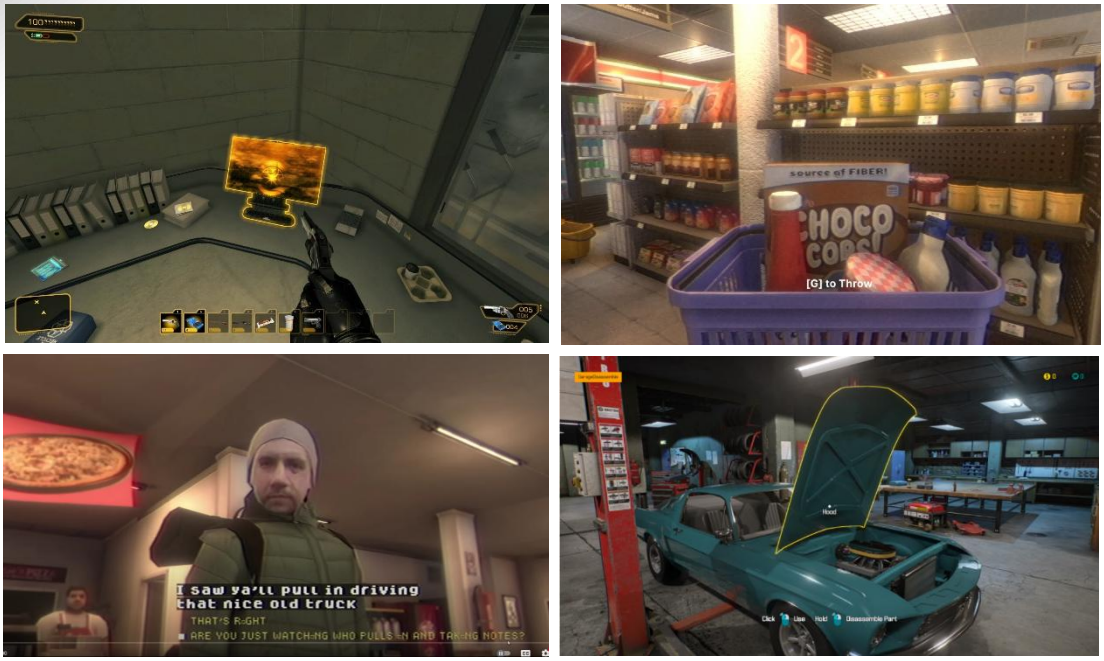


Figure 7. *In-world interface and HUD examples shown in order:* ***Deus Ex: Human Revolution*** *(2011),* ***Fears to Fathom – Carson House*** *(2021),* ***Fears to Fathom – Norwood Hitchhike*** *(2023), and* ***Car Mechanic Simulator*** *(2018).*